

Primary Source Reading: The Analects of Confucius

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.02 — The Universal Witness Translated by James Legge (1861)

Before you read: The *Analects* is a collection of sayings attributed to Confucius (551–479 BCE), compiled by his students after his death. Unlike Hammurabi's code, it does not claim divine authorship or threaten legal punishment. As you read, ask what Confucius appeals to instead — what makes an action right, on his account, if not a god's command or a king's law?

Filial Piety

Mang I asked what filial piety was. The Master said, "It is not being disobedient." ... That parents, when alive, be served according to propriety; that, when dead, they should be buried according to propriety; and that they should be sacrificed to according to propriety.

Tsze-yu asked what filial piety was. The Master said, "The filial piety of now-a-days means the support of one's parents. But dogs and horses likewise are able to do something in the way of support; — without reverence, what is there to distinguish the one support given from the other?"

The One Word for a Whole Life

Tsze-kung asked, saying, "Is there one word which may serve as a rule of practice for all one's life?" The Master said, "Is not RECIPROCITY such a word? What you do not want done to yourself, do not do to others."

Virtue and the Superior Man

The Master said, "It is virtuous manners which constitute the excellence of a neighborhood. If a man in selecting a residence, do not fix on one where such prevail, how can he be wise?"

The Master said, "The superior man, in the world, does not set his mind either for anything, or against anything; what is right he will follow."

The Master said, "The superior man thinks of virtue; the small man thinks of comfort."

Self-Examination

The philosopher Tsang said, "I daily examine myself on three points:— whether, in transacting business for others, I may have been not faithful; whether, in intercourse with friends, I may have been not sincere; whether I may have not mastered and practiced the instructions of my teacher."

After you read: Notice that Confucius, unlike Hammurabi, grounds none of these teachings in a threatened penalty or a divine decree. When Confucius is asked what filial piety is, he answers with a question about reverence and inward attitude, not a rule with a punishment attached. As you fill in your comparison chart, ask what — if anything — is doing the same job in Confucius's teaching that the gods and the king do in Hammurabi's code.